Just Food
Alimentation juste

Community Gardening Network of Ottawa
Réseau de jardinage communautaire d'Ottawa

Organic Container Gardening

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About the Community Gardening Network

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Today, we will cover:



- Equipment
- Choosing Plants
- Setup
- Maintenance
- Harvesting
- Seed Starting
- Additional Support

Equipment

- Containers
  - consider depth depending on what you want to grow
  - drainage is very important (may want to protect the surface under the containers)













Get creative and recycle!

Equipment

- Soil
  - Organic
  - Potting/container mix is best
  - Don't use seed starting mix







Equipment

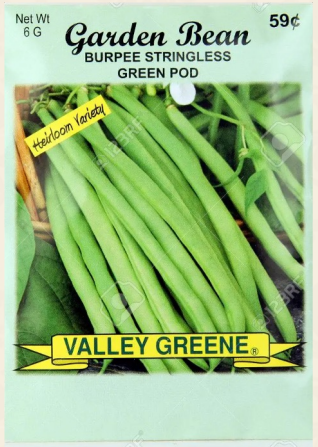
- Seeds
  - organic or non-GMO
  - Just Food Seed & Soil, Seedy Saturday
  - consider seed sharing with neighbours

GAIA ORGANIC SEEDS

Northern Wildflowers

NORTHERN SEEDS
SEMENCES NORDIQUES

OSC



West Coast Seeds

Equipment

- Seedlings
  - Just Food SeedLing Saturday (May)
  - Focus on buying seedlings that are more challenging to grow from seed
    - Buy as seedlings: tomatoes, peppers, eggplants, etc
    - Buy as seeds: lettuce, radish, carrots, beans, peas, etc





Equipment

- Supports
  - trellises, poles, cages
- Watering Devices
  - Watering can with gentle spray or a spray bottle for seeds











Equipment

- Season Extension Materials (Not necessary)
  - Frost cloth, Cloches (Can be made by cutting bottom of water jug - keep the lid!)







Choosing Plants

- Seeds vs Seedlings
  - Make a list of what you like to eat, then research requirements to start from seed
    - i.e. tomatoes and peppers need to be started indoors in March/April, and may need additional equipment like grow lights
    - i.e. lettuce, radishes, carrots don't like to be transplanted and are best grown directly in the soil
  - Decide which plants would best suit your space, time, and commitment

Choosing Plants

- How to read a seed packet
  - DTM = Days to Maturity
  - Container variety
    - "Dwarf" varieties
  - Sun Exposure
    - Full Sun = 6 - 8 hours (but more is better)
    - Part Sun/Shade = 4 - 6 hours
    - Shade = no more than 4 hours direct sun
  - Trellising
  - Seed depth
  - Plant size (keep an eye on height)



Choosing Plants

- Fall planting
  - Central Ottawa's anticipated first frost date is Sept 26th
  - Take that date and count backwards to now to calculate how many days you have
  - I.E. today is Aug 8, we have about 49 days until our first expected frost
    - Consider season extension methods to stretch that
    - Consider methods to speed up germination

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What kinds of plants can you grow now from seed?

- Lettuces (leaf)
- Arugula
- Spinach
- Peas (soak overnight to speed germination)
- Kale (sow densely to harvest as baby kale)
- Carrots (ensure the soil doesn't dry out)
- Basil
- Bok choy
- Radishes
- Turnips
- Beets (harvest greens)
- Bush beans (ASAP! Soak overnight to speed up germination)

Choosing Plants

- Select varieties that will give you more bang for your buck
  - you might not want to grow a one-time harvest crop like cauliflower or broccoli which takes a while to grow to maturity
  - cut-and-come-again greens (kale, loose-leaf lettuce, arugula, green onion)
  - cherry tomatoes, snacking/hot peppers, peas, beans (look for bush or shorter vining), herbs, lettuces, fingerling eggplants
  - crops that have shorter DTM so you can plant again (radishes, bok choy, arugula)

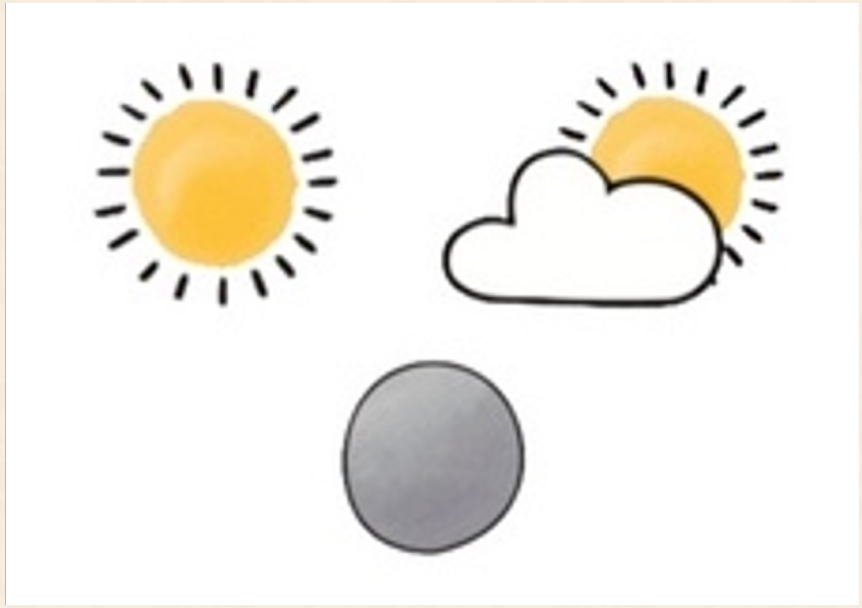
Choosing Plants

- Consider your available containers and their depth
  - You generally need soil 6-9" deep for plants like beans, lettuce, spring onions, short carrots, radishes, spinach
  - You generally need soil 12" deep for tomatoes, squash, peppers, long carrots, etc

The bigger the container for your plants, the better yield you can expect!

Choosing Plants

- Sun exposure
  - Observe your growing space's sun exposure and determine if there are different spots that get more/less sun



Choosing Plants

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Full Sun (more than 6-8 hours)

- **Beans:** bush beans are best. Plant 3 in an 8" wide pot.
- **Tomatoes:** cherry tomatoes are best, they need a 6" pot. For bigger tomatoes, they need a 12" pot. Tomatoes need lots of sun and need to be tied up to a stick.
- **Peppers:** need lots of sun. Tie to a stick to hold them up. Plant one in a 12" pot
- **Radishes:** plant 2 inches apart, or three in a 6" pot. Ready to eat in a month.
- **Summer Squash, Zucchini:** need 2 foot (24") deep and 2 foot (24") wide pot (note: buy varieties designed for growing in containers)
- **Cucumbers** varieties designed for pot gardening.

Choosing Plants

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  - Observe your growing space's sun exposure and determine if there are different spots that get more/less sun

Part Sun (4-6 hours)

- **Beets:** plant 3" apart, use when leaves 5 to 8" tall, or after two months
- **Carrots:** plant 2" apart. Ready to eat in two to three months
- **Chives, and Onions:** need 6" wide pot
- **Garlic:** plant garlic cloves 6" apart, pick when the plant top dies
- **Herbs:** all kinds grow well in pots, bring indoors in winter
- **Lettuce:** plant leafy lettuce, 4" apart
- **Spinach:** needs to be kept cool and wet, plant 6" apart

Choosing Plants

- Don't forget about flowers!
  - Pest repellent (marigolds)
  - Pest traps (nasturtiums - also edible!)
  - Pollinator attractants
    - If you don't get pollinators on your balcony, you may need to consider pollinating certain plants with a paintbrush







Setup



- Try to maximum your space
  - Can you hang a railing planter?
  - Do you have hooks you can hang a planter from?
  - Is there any shelving you can use?
- Put plants in their ideal locations
  - If some spots receive full sun, make sure that's where you put your sun-loving plants

Maintenance

- Watering
  - in the height of summer, this may need to be done daily
  - consider windiness of balconies
  - use mulch
    - straw, leaves, compost, newspaper



- Pruning
  - cut off dried out or yellowed foliage

- Fertilizing
  - Use a water soluble fertilizer
  - add compost if you are reusing soil (i.e. if you harvest radishes and want to re-plant)

- Pest control
  - inspect plants regularly - organic gardening is easier when issues are caught earlier
    - there are many apps you can use to identify issues
    - consult the CGN Garden Guide for remedies

Maintenance

- Fertilizing
  - Use a water soluble fertilizer - for fruiting plants, apply weekly
  - Add compost if you are reusing soil (i.e. if you harvest radishes and want to re-plant)
  - Add compost/slow release fertilizer if you are not using a potting soil





For Fall:
If you use potting soil, you shouldn't need to worry about fertilizer

Harvesting

- General best practice is to harvest earlier in the morning before heat is too strong (so you aren't picking while wilted)
- Consider the variety of veg you are growing -
  - i.e. determinant tomato you'd pick all at once, indeterminant you'd pick but keep letting it grow OR cut-and-come again lettuces
- Once you have harvested your crop for the season, you can keep the soil that is in the container but it will need to be amended next year to use again - add compost!
- For crops that are earlier to harvest (radish, lettuce, bok choy), consider succession planting - plant every few weeks, or if you are on limited space, plant again after you've harvested

Seed Starting

- A few tips and tricks to seed starting - if you want to get a head start on germinating some seeds
  - Pre-sprout some seeds by soaking (think larger seeds like peas and beans)
  - Sow your seeds in your pot, keep the soil moist, cover with plastic wrap to create a greenhouse effect, remove once germinated
- Consider winter sowing for starting your seeds next year





Extra consideration

- You can plant more than one crop in a container if you are intentional about it (i.e. basil around a tomato plant)
  - But you need to consider the container size, to ensure that there is no stunted growth
- Join your Local Buy Nothing Group on Facebook for free resources





For Additional Support

- Take a look at the CGN Garden Guide
  - A link will be sent out to you after the workshop
- Contact us with questions!
  - communitygardening@justfood.ca
- Join your local gardening groups
  - Sign up for the CGN Newsletter
  - Join Facebook communities
    - Edible Ottawa Gardens Group